> *Secretary Gates*: I would add . . . I would just add one other thing. The thing to remember here is that this is a huge amount of raw data . . . There is no accountability. There is no sense of responsibility. It is sort of thrown out there for take as you will and damn the consequences.
>
> *Journalist*: With all due respect, you didn't answer the question.

Within hours of these statements, the expression 'Julian Assange has blood on his hands' had entered the language. If you Google the words 'Assange' and 'blood' you will see, by the number of hits, that those two words together suggest that, at least in the media consciousness, I am associated with the concept of 'blood on hands' to a greater extent than Richard Nixon, Suharto and Pontius Pilate put together. That is how the modern world of communications works. Without any evidence – any evidence at all – of casualties resulting from our attempt to let people see what was happening in that war, I was able to be dubbed as a person with 'blood on his hands'. It is one of those statements careless people enjoy, and it has blunt currency, but there is no basis for it in fact. The very sinister thing is how it is then taken up by other commentators, not only as a statement of fact, but as a true reflection of the original statement. It is neither. Look again at Admiral Mullen's statement. He said, 'They might already have on their hands the blood . . .' The words 'they' and 'might' are quickly shaved off by the wider media and suddenly 'Julian Assange has blood on his hands'. And so, something that wasn't true in the first place breeds even sharper untruths, until, by the end, one is forced to embody not only a fiction, but a fictionalisation of a previous fiction, without recourse.

We've become so used to these procedures we've begun to think them entirely normal. But they are heinous. And every day now, if I wanted to, I could spend my time rebuffing the fictions of foes and friends alike, none of whom, it turns out, can be immune from the contaminating force of lies. This is not only a problem for me, of course, and I begin to feel sorry for anybody who was ever stupid or vain enough to think they might do well to live their lives in the public eye. It's a losing battle. One is forced to become like a cypher in the work of Charles Dickens, living out an endless Jarndyce versus Jarndyce of the self, in which evidence can only mount and